

EXT. The Ocean - DAY

The scene opens in the middle of the ocean, a tiny lifeboat a mere dot on the vast expanse of the ocean. It glides along the gleaming water, going wherever the ripples take them. On the boat are two individuals. One, is lying against the lifeboat, their hand hanging off its edge. Their eyes are empty, gazing into the ocean. This is Alex. On the other end of the lifeboat is Charlie, going through their remaining inventory. The bag contains 1 flare gun, 1 life jacket and 1 ration bar. Charlie sighs and zips the bag up, lying against the boat, facing Alex. Charlie looks at Alex, who looks out at the water.

Charlie

We're running out. There's barely enough for the two of us.

(Alex stays quiet)

Charlie:

Are you not gonna say anything?

Alex looks at Charlie, eyes hardened.

Alex

What is there to say? We knew this was bound to happen when we ended up on this boat.

Charlie, irritated:

No. What was bound to happen was someone coming and rescuing us.

Alex

Yeah? Look around you, Charlie.

(Charlie looks around)

Alex

What do you see?

(Charlie stays quiet)

Alex

Exactly. This is our fate. And the sooner you accept it, the better.

Charlie (quiet but determined):

No, my fate is not gonna be becoming fish food. Someone will come and rescue us. Whether you think so or not.

Alex:

Whatever floats your boat. (sarcastically)

They sit in silence and it stretches for hours. The sun almost below the horizon, settling a warm orange hue on them. Nothing out of the ordinary happens except for the ocean's usual sounds. Charlie and Alex are sitting in the same positions as before. Charlie looks at Alex and looks back to the lifeboat under his feet. Charlie looks back up at the noise of Alex's stomach grumbling. He sighs as he notices Alex's sunken face, droopy eyes and dark circles. Charlie sighs and picks up the packet of food and slides it across the floor towards Alex. Alex gazes down at it and slides it back to Charlie.

Charlie

You need to eat.

Alex

I don't want it.

Charlie

That's what you said when I asked you last time. And the time before that.

And the time before that.

Alex keeps looking at the water. (pause)

Charlie

Why do you refuse to eat?

Alex

You should have it.

Charlie

Stop trying to dodge the question.

(silence)

Charlie

Alex, look. I don't know what you think you're trying to achieve here by holding off on food but you *need* to eat. You won't be able to survive much longer if you keep going on like this! Look at me!

Alex looks at Charlie, opens his mouth to quip back, but Charlie cuts in.

Charlie (increasingly agitated)

Do you think that's fair for me? You die, leaving me alone to carry all the memories of this- this wreck all by myself? How selfish...
You can't die.

Alex looks at Charlie, lips parted in shock, before averting his gaze with a slight shake to his head. Silent settles over them again. Minutes turn into hours as the sun sets below the horizon. Charlie rummages through the emergency kit once again, trying to give himself to do something, feel something, anything to prevent him from succumbing to madness. He looks over and sees Alex with his hand still out into the water.

Charlie

Get your hand out of the water. You don't want something
biting it off.

Alex ponders for a second before slowly pulling it out of the water and wiping the hand on his shirt. Charlie zips the emergency kit close and the ship's name engraved on the kit catches his attention. He lets his hands graze over it lightly, his eyes slipping close as his breath shudders. He doesn't look at Alex when he speaks, breath barely over a whisper.

Charlie:

Do you remember? (humorless chuckle) of course you do, who am I kidding?

Charlie shakes his head a little as Alex turns to look at him curious. Charlie turns to look at him

Charlie

The night of the wreck. (pause) You know I don't
Understand you.

Charlie

You saved me that night...I had almost given up, almost let the tides take me under, but you caught me before that happened. You seemed very keen on saving me. Getting us both on the lifeboat safe. (pause). But now, it's like you don't even care what happens to us anymore. I don't understand... Why save us make us suffer like this when all this could've ended that night.

(pause)

Alex

Not us. You

The night when the hull cracked and the water flooded in, I waited for it to take me. I couldn't reach the vests... Didn't care enough to try. But then I saw you, going under, fighting like hell just to get another breath in and... I don't know, I couldn't ignore that, I had to do something. And so I did. The one time I decide to do something right, I drag you into this hell, instead of letting it end then.

Charlie

What do you mean? Mess up your life?

But Alex turns away again, Charlie opens his mouth to press again. But Alex cuts in.

Alex

Drop it Charlie.

A few beats of silence pass by, the occasional splash of the waves hitting the boat fill the air. The sun has long set, but neither of them seem interested in sleeping. Charlie speaks again.

Charlie

So, what did you do before all this?

Alex lets out a humorless laugh and turns to Charlie.

Alex

Why?

Charlie (shrugs, smile)

I dunno, guess I just wanna get to know the guy
I'm stuck with for the unforeseeable future

Alex looks at him, amused, before looking back at the horizon

Alex

I worked. The typical 9-5 corporate dream.
Only I wouldn't wish that upon anyone.

Charlie

Was it that bad?

Alex (shrugs)
I mean, it paid the bills. But other than that
It was horrible.

Charlie
Hmm. What about your family?

Alex
Ahh, family. What *can* I say. Parents dead wife walked out. (pause)
We had a daughter.
(pause)
Had.

Charlie (long silence)
I'm sorry

Alex (shrugs)
It's fine. (pause) What about you? Job?

Charlie (smiles)
Yeah. I work as a social worker.
You know, just help the homeless get back on their feet. That stuff

Alex
You must sleep well at night then. Knowing how many
Lives you've impacted

Charlie
It's not always sunshine and rainbows, though.
Sometimes it gets so hard I can do nothing for them except cry. But
sometimes their smile and their will to continue fighting, I don't
know... It keeps me going.

Alex (smiles)
I knew it.

Charlie (confused)
What?

Alex
Nothing

Charlie
Alex. Tell me.

Alex
It's something worth going back to.

Charlie
What do you mean?

Alex
Your job. Your life. (pause)
You enjoy what you do. It's worth going
Back to

Charlie looks at Alex again, carefully taking in his every detail. He looks at Alex's hand hanging out the boat into the water, the way his eyes look out at the horizon. And then at the ration packet sitting untouched at the side. His eyes soften in realization, lips parting.

Charlie
That's why you gave up. Isn't it?

Alex doesn't respond, but turns to face Charlie.

Charlie
Until you saw me in the water?

Charlie
You think I've got more to live for than
You. That's why you pulled me out. And that's why
You refuse to eat.

Alex's eyes and jaw harden. They refuse to meet Charlie's eyes, looking down at the lifeboat. Charlie inches closer to Alex, trying to hold him, but Alex swats him away.

Alex
Don't, Charlie.

Charlie
Do you really think that? That
your life is not worth as much as mine?

Alex
I don't want your pity Charlie

Charlie
I'm not pitying you, Alex. I'm trying to

understand you.

For a while no one speaks. Charlie watches Alex, but Alex keeps his eyes fixed on the horizon.

Charlie
Do you not miss it?

Alex turns to look at him

Alex
What do you mean?

Charlie
Your home. Your life. The one you had before all of this.

Alex
I thought I made it clear already, that
I don't have anything to go back to.

Charlie
Nothing at all? Not even, I don't know,
your neighbourhood dog?

Alex
No, Charlie.

Charlie
(silence)
Well what about now. Now that you're away from it,
Do you really not want to get back to it?

Alex
(silence)

Charlie
You know what's funny? You literally just saw this guy kicking at the
water and went after him. And you didn't even know me well enough.
(pause)

Alex
That's different

Charlie

How Alex? Please explain it to me. Because from what I see right now, you think a life is something precious and worth saving... unless the life is yours.

Alex
You don't understand

Charlie
What don't I understand, Alex? That you've given up? That you're too weak to fight longer? That you are just waiting for me to accept your sacrifice and let you die? Making you feel like you've achieved something? Cuz I understand pretty well.

Alex
Watch your mouth, Charlie

Charlie
Yeah? What are you gonna do? Nothing you do will hurt me more than you giving up this fight and leaving me alone, Alex

Alex
Stop it, Charlie! If I don't want to go back, then you can't make the decision for me.

Charlie
And *you* made the decision for me when you pulled me back on the lifeboat! If you could do it then, why can't I do it for you, now?

Alex
You think I don't know we're dying? You think I wanna sit on this wooden thing and think day and night about the life I left behind and the life it could've been?

Alex
You think I didn't dream of a better life? A good loving family, a home, a good paying job, someone to get back to every night?

(pause)
It wasn't supposed to be like this, Charlie. And I can't bear to go back to that life.

Alex's voice cracks and tears are streaming down Alex's face, as he tries wiping away at it furiously.

Alex

I spent years thinking it would get better. I thought if I worked harder, if I kept going, if I just held on a little longer, it'll all be fine.

Alex laughs humorously

Alex

I kept working so hard I forgot who I was and what I was working for. And then one day, everything just disappeared in a blink of an eye. My parents, wife, daughter...

Charlie

So then you stopped wanting anything. Thought that you'll lose yourself again. So you stopped.

Alex nods

Charlie

And then you saw me. (pause) And you couldn't let me die. Cuz deep down you knew the worth of the life you lost. You wanted me to have a fair shot at it.

Alex

I see why you're a social worker

Charlie

I'm not going to tell you everything is going to be okay. Neither of us know whether it's going to be

(pause)

But that's the good thing no? You don't know. You don't know if it's going to be worse or better. And there's no way to really know unless you actually live it.

Alex opens his mouth to say something, but Charlie continues

Charlie

You don't have to go back to your old life. You don't have to completely abandon it, but maybe you can learn from it and build a new life.

Alex (smiles)

Build? With what, Charlie

Charlie

Dunno, but we'll figure it out.

Alex

We?

Charlie

Yes.

Alex (smile)

You don't even know me. What if I scare you away?

Charlie

Hey, I've seen you at your worst. I doubt it can go lower than that.

Alex laughs. Charlie puts his hand out for Alex to take it.

Charlie

You don't have to figure it all out in a day. But at least stay to see that day.

Alex stares at his hand for a while before taking it. Charlie stares out at the sunrise, and Alex follows his gaze. Charlie reaches out to the food ration and holds it out for Alex. Alex looks at it, at Charlie and then takes it. He breaks off two pieces, one for himself and one for Charlie. He hesitates for a while before taking a bite. Charlie doesn't say anything and just munches on his bite. They sit together, watching the sun rise over the ocean. For the first time in a long while, Alex closes his eyes, in peace and warmth.